

The Role That Was Not Here

By: Feng Rui Liu

CHARACTERS:

LIAM, a poor student who came to Paris for a play, with talent and hope, gradually learns to reclaim his voice and self-worth.

DANIEL, the director of the production, whose authority and pursuit of control shape the rehearsal room and challenge Liam's confidence

MEI, the leader of a new troupe, who values honesty and growth, offering Liam a space where he is heard and respected

CHRIS, Liam's roommate in Boston, who grounds him in reality and represents the financial and emotional cost of dream.

JULIEN, a lead performer frequently absent from rehearsals, whose invisibility highlights the imbalance and unfairness within the production

SETTING:

United States and France, 2025. Liam was having his exchange program in Boston and got an invitation from his so-called friend Daniel in Paris.

Scene 1 — Boston, February

Scene 1 Setting:

A snowy Boston sidewalk. Freezing wind howls. Streetlights glow in the falling snow. Liam walks with two friends, rubbing his hands together, shoulders hunched.

LIAM:

Ugh. Boston in February is gonna kill me.

(His phone buzzes. He stops walking.)

Hold on. Daniel just messaged me.

(Reads. His eyes widen.)

He's inviting me to an audition for Orpheus.

I guess that means Paris... for me?

How can I afford that?

I can't even speak French.

Chris:

Bro, you look like you just won the lottery.

Liam

Do I? Because it feels like a bill I can't pay.

But yeah. Someone finally thinks I'm good enough.

I've always been overlooked.

(Liam hesitates.)

Chris:

(Chris interrupts him)

You still owe me rent.

You are late by a couple months and I have been covering you.

(Liam grips his phone tightly, like a lifeline.)

Liam:

I'm going to Paris. I'll sell my keyboard. I'll sleep on floors.

Lights fade.

End of the Scene

Scene 2 — Outside the Opéra de Paris, October

Scene 2 Setting:

Early morning. Liam exits a train station, dragging a suitcase. Paris is grand, unfamiliar.

Liam:

(He slowly turns, taking it all in.)

Whoa... That building looks like it was built for the king.

(He checks his phone, re-reading the address. Nods to himself.)

Stay focused, Liam.

*(He walks down a hallway toward a rehearsal room. Voices are heard inside--
Laughter, overlapping chatter. As Liam approaches, the voices suddenly stop.)
(Liam slows. He wipes his hands on his pants, fixes collar, etc. The silence feels
strange. After a moment, he knocks lightly.)*

Daniel opens the door with a tight, professional smile. Another actor inside avoids eye contact.

Daniel:

Liam! There you are. Good to see you.

(He hands Liam a bottle.)

Here—some water. A little welcome gesture.

(The label reads: Vinaigre d'alcool. Liam doesn't notice the bottle is already opened)

Liam:

Oh, thanks.

(Sniffs it, puzzled.)

Uh... are you sure this doesn't smell a little... strange?

Daniel:

Just drink it. You're fine.

(Liam takes a big sip. Freezes. His eyes water.)

Liam:

Oh. Wow.

That is... strong.

(He squints and he jumps)

(He feels embarrassed, forces an awkward laugh.)

So---should we start the audition?

Daniel:

Relax. Pages six through nine.

(Liam stands center stage. Daniel sits, arms crossed.)

Liam:
(deep breath)
King of Shadows~*(singing)*
(He coughs hard.)
Sorry... let me try again.
King of shades~*(singing)*

Daniel:
No.
Not like that.
(Daniel sings the same phrase, perfectly, without looking at Liam)
Again.

(Liam tries once more.)

Daniel:
That's all for today. Thanks for helping out with the play.

Liam:
Could I try again—one more time?

Daniel:
I'll call you tomorrow.

Lights shift.

Montage:
Liam is on his phone, wearing his headphones and practicing the song.
Recording voice notes.
Phone lighting up again and again.

Liam: *(voice message)*
I've been working on my Tenor pitch. I made a new recording—I think it's better.

Liam :*(another message)*
So... am I playing Orpheus?

(Phone buzzes. A text from Daniel.)

DANIEL *(text)*
You came all the way from Boston to Paris. It would be hard for you to go back.
I decided to give you a spot in the ensemble.

LIAM
(confused)

So... was I ever really up for Orpheus?
Or was I just the person who could get here?

Daniel: *(text)*

Keep working.

It's about the team and where you fit in best not about winning the role.

(Liam forces a smile. His shoulders tense.)

Scene 3 — Rehearsal Breakdown & Confrontation

Scene 3 Setting:

Studio. Afternoon. Half the ensemble is present. No one talks. Everyone avoids Daniel's eyes. Music stops abruptly during the Ensemble practice.

Daniel:

(voice sharp)

Again. From the cue. Liam—your entrance was late. Again.

Liam:

I know. I'm—trying.

Daniel:

Everyone is trying. That's not enough. Not here.

(The ensemble stares. Someone shifts uncomfortably.)

Liam:

Look, I messed up.

Daniel:

(steps closer)

You've been missing signals for days.

Even the smallest thing you got it wrong.

Are you even listening to this room?

Liam:

I am. I just...every time I move, I'm guessing what you want.

And when I guess wrong, you're already yelling before I finish.

Daniel:

Because I don't have time to babysit.

You think Paris will wait for you?

You think anyone will?

Liam:

(quiet, hurt)

Then tell me once.

Let me do it without fear.

Daniel:

(chuckles, almost cruel)

No one gives second chances.

Not to an outsider.

(A beat. Liam's jaw tightens. The ensemble looks away. The silence says enough.)

Liam:
Then I'll go somewhere where they respect my talent and give me encouragement.

Daniel:
They won't.
You'll just fall apart somewhere else.

Liam:
Maybe.
But at least I won't disappear.
(Liam drops his script. Walks out. he walks out mid-music, everyone stops, he removes a costume piece and leaves it.)

Daniel:
(too soft for others to hear)
You know how many things I have to fix?
Lights fade.

March —First Pre-Performance.
After the show — Rehearsal room.
(Actors exit quickly, avoiding eye contact. Liam sits alone, makeup half-removed.)

Liam:
I did everything I could.
(He scrolls through his phone. A long chain of angry messages from Daniel.)

Liam:
(reading)
"You weren't present." "You didn't listen." "You embarrassed the production."
(He laughs once, bitter.)
Of course.
If something breaks, it's my name first.

Later that evening — Emergency meeting.*(online meeting)*

Daniel:
Look at this, the timing, the focus.
(Turns to Liam.)
What were you thinking?

Liam:
I was thinking we needed a pulse.
I was trying to save the moment.

Daniel:

Alive? This wasn't alive. This was chaos.

(Gestures to empty seats.)

This is Paris. Standards are higher here.

Liam:

Then where is everyone?

(Beat.)

Where's Julien? Where are the leads? Why is it always the same three people fixing everything?

Daniel:

(lower, more serious)

You don't understand how things work here.

Liam:

Then say it.

Say why the rules only land on some of us.

(Silence.)

Daniel:

Let's move on.

(Liam waits. Daniel tired but defensive.)

Liam:

You invited me from Boston because you said you saw potential.

I crossed an ocean for this.

Daniel:

And I gave you an opportunity. A fair shot like everyone else.

Liam

You lied to me.

(Steps closer.)

You promised me Orpheus. Then you put me in the ensemble and told me to be grateful.

Daniel:

You weren't ready.

Liam:

How could I be ready if you never let me try?

(Beat.)

Every rehearsal, I show up. I listen. I work. And every mistake—mine or not—lands on me.

Daniel:

I need control. That's how productions survive.

Liam:

No. That's how people stop speaking.

(A long silence.)

Liam:

I'm quitting the ensemble.

Daniel:

You're emotional. Stay. I need you. Don't let your team down.

Liam:

You need someone who won't talk back.

I am not afraid of you anymore.

Daniel:

If you leave, don't expect another chance.

Liam:

I'm done waiting for permission.

(He exits.)

Scene 4 — A New Troupe

Scene 4 Setting: Conservatory hallway. Evening light through tall windows.

Liam wanders, defeated. He almost turns back—then hears music. Not perfect, but alive. (He follows it.) Inside an open studio, a troupe rehearses. Someone messes up. They laugh. Mei notices Liam.

Mei
You've been standing there a while.

LIAM
Sorry. I didn't mean to interrupt.

Mei:
You look nervous.

Liam:
I'm... not supposed to be here.

Mei:
Then don't "be here." Just listen.
Or, if you want, sing something.
No pressure.

(Liam nods. He sings trembling at first, then stronger.)

Liam:
Somewhere in the middle no where...

Mei:
(considering)
I think you did very well.
You're honest.
You take the time you need. That's good quality.
This try was better than the last two auditions put together.

Liam:
Does that mean... it's a yes?

Mei:
(smiles)
If you show up tomorrow at 6, it's a yes.

Final Performance — Night.
Lights rise on the stage. Their harmonies are not perfect, but they breathe in sync,

*present with one another. Mei's group joined together
Liam stands center. SONG ENDS. Applause — real, warm, human.*

Liam:

Let's take a photo.

*Everyone on the Ensemble team comes together under a new team.
In the back of the theater, Daniel stands.
Not the center of the storm now — just one person in the dark.
He leaves early, showing disrespect. Liam watches him leave in satisfaction.*

In Auditorium:

Mei:

(soft, beside him)

Welcome home.

(He inhales.)

You just successfully finished your first play.

How does it feel?

Will you go back to Boston after all?

LIAM (V.O.):

I don't know.

But I can breathe here.

That's enough.

Blackout.

End of the play.